

Show, Don't Tell: Your Frame-Worthy Mini-Guide

Let's say you had a stressful day.

You tell it to your friend on the phone. You say: "I had a stressful day."

He says: "Oh, I'm sorry."

But somehow you can't help but feel that he hasn't grasped the magnitude of the teeth-crumbling, nerve-shredding course of your day.

It's only natural he doesn't know. He hasn't seen you driving through rush hour traffic, one finger on the steering wheel, while arranging appointments on the cell phone, and wrapping a birthday present with your left toe. He hasn't seen you creeping in through the front door on your gums at 11 PM, loaded with papers and shopping bags.

He was *told* how you feel, not *shown*. "Stressful" is an abstract word. And we only fully experience things we are *shown*.

Another example: The other day on the radio, I heard that "two people were killed in a car accident."

Did I feel for these poor people?

If I'm honest, not at all. They were just news on the radio. I was just given a piece of information. When we are told a summary, we don't *feel* in our guts what happened. That's just human nature.

But what if I had witnessed their car crash, seeing their blood and their skulls cracked open, hearing their screams? What if I had been talking to their crying families? Would I have felt for them then?

You bet, I would have felt for them more than you can imagine.

You can't imagine right now, because I just told you, I didn't show you. I would have tears streaming down my cheeks. There, now I showed you.

Excuse my extreme example taken from our media-filtered reality. But such is the power of *'Show, don't tell'!*

And when narrating your stories, you should use it to your advantage.

When you just *tell* somebody, you are taking away from them experiencing your scene. They might as well read an instruction manual.

'Telling' is like a big neon sign. It's the most obvious clue you are reading an amateurish, inexperienced writer. Don't do it!

So in honor of *showing*, I will lay out for you how exactly you can use the good, old 'Show, don't tell' to create unforgettable stories. In this you, find the answers to the following questions:

- Why are you always tempted to 'tell'?
- Which words are strong indicators that you are 'telling'?
- Which tricks can you employ to avoid 'telling'?
- You will also get lots and lots of examples, so 'Show, don't tell' will become ingrained in your DNA by the time you finish this post...

Show Don't Tell Meaning

Which one of the following two snippets pulls you deeper into the story?

This one:

Aaron was a cheerful young doctor, and he loved his car dearly. It was a beautiful and very expensive vehicle, and he liked to feel its horsepower below him when he ignited the engine.

Or this one:

Aaron stepped out into the bright summer sun with a smile on his face. Whistling a little tune, he walked up to his Porsche, and admired its shiny, brand-new body and rims. “Good morning, Thunderboy!” he said, and he couldn’t help but bend down and press a gentle kiss on its shiny black hood. He dropped his doctor’s bag on the passenger seat, hopped in and let the motor roar up.

Obviously, the second example hooks us much more, and draws us quicker into the story. It lets us *experience* the scene directly.

And that is why in your scenes, you should show, and not tell.

The difference between those two is really like the difference between watching a 3D movie and reading a review of the same movie online.

Telling means that you are putting quick labels and broad, simple adjectives on things. You are *claiming* something is so-and-so. You summarize.

Showing means that you describe details, and use action, emotion and dialogue to paint a scene for your reader. You are *demonstrating* that something is so-and-so.

When describing nature, you should seize upon small details, arranging them so that the reader will see an image in his mind after he closes his eyes. For instance: you will capture the truth of a moonlit night if you’ll write that a gleam like starlight shone from the pieces of a broken bottle, and then the dark, plump shadow of a dog or wolf appeared.

Beware! The Looming Danger

Telling is easy. You just pile up a couple of adjectives , and baaaam, you can say “I wrote a story.”

Showing is hard. You have to do brain work and think about “Which details can I include?” and “How could I demonstrate this in a visual way?” You have to immerse yourself completely into that scene, and sometimes you have to think backwards how to demonstrate something.

That’s why *telling* takes a lot less effort than *showing*. The difference is like claiming you just cleaned up your room versus actually doing it. It’s very tempting to just take the lower road and tell.

But don’t do that!

Be aware of that temptation, and don’t give in to it. If you put in the effort to *show*, your story will be so much more gripping and engaging, and will be a much more exciting experience.

Now let me show (not tell) you how to do it :

1. Use Details

The first and most obvious thing to do when you *show*, *don’t tell*, is describing details. Be as generous as Santa Claus with details!

Make the *spooky house* a house *with dark windows, shattered lanterns, a doorway covered in cobwebs, and an overgrown path leading up to it.*

Don’t say *Kate is angry*. Instead, describe how Kate *bangs the table with her clenched fist, her face turning slightly red, screaming "I can’t believe it!"*

Unfold the scene in front of your mind’s eye, and those engaging details will come to you easily.

2. Try Not to Use These Words

Some words are signs that you are telling, not showing. These bad words are (view them as villains): Adjectives and any form of the word “to be.” They will lure you to tell, not show. You must resist their evil powers!

With adjectives, you can put a quick label on anything; something is “beautiful, big, funny, strange...” The same is true for variations of “to be”: “he was, she is, it was...” All of these lead to quick labeling, rather than showing.

But I will give you an anti-spell against their evilness. The formula is to ask yourself:

How do I notice she is quick/he is funny/it is delightful/etc...?

Answer yourself that question, and you will have a great list of descriptions to show to your readers. This question is like your secret weapon against all adjectives.

3. Use Nouns and Verbs Instead

On the other hand, here are the good words, the Batmen of your dictionary (I’m so happy I got to use the plural of “Batman” for once): They are the nouns and verbs.

If you use nouns and verbs, they will *force* you to describe. They will force you to do the right thing, like your mom shoving spinach down your throat when you were little.

Instead of writing *he was a grumpy man* (adjective), you now write, *he rarely talked, and when he saw the kids playing, he let a grunt out of the corner of his mouth* (verbs and nouns).

4. Use senses

Using senses is pure showing!

Instead of *a lush garden*, make it *a garden with wild red and orange flowers, and a thick, sweet smell*.

Instead of writing, *'diving into the water was pleasant'*, write, *'the water felt cool and fresh and clean on his sore skin.'*

When you describe a sensual experience, oftentimes your reader will have experienced it herself, and remember her experience while reading. She will then immediately and very intensely hear, smell, feel or taste the objects you lay out for her.

5. Dialogue is Your Friend

Any dialogue line you use is *always* showing!

That's because a dialogue line is reflecting straight up what's happening in the scene, moment-by-moment. It's never the author speaking.

So instead of telling your audience *Don Pedro was a powerful man*, write:

"The guy in the white suite, who just got off the Royce Rolls... that's Don Pedro," she muttered. "He seems to always get his way. People he doesn't like... they just disappear. His power seems to have no limits!"

In that direct speech we showed in part (*white suit; Royce Rolls*), and in part we told (*seems to always get his will; people just disappear; power seems to have no limits*).

But all the telling in this snippet is no problem. Because the person talking is the *character*; it's not you, the author... you are off the hook! A very

convenient and perfectly fine way to sneak some telling in through the backdoor.

6. Dialogue Tags Are Not Always Your Friends

Now dialogue tags are something else entirely. They can very well be telling, and they often tell in a cringeworthy way.

A dialogue tag is the little attachment to a dialogue line that assigns a speaker (e.g. “he screamed,” “she said angrily”).

Dialogue tags are often horrible cesspools of showing, so please be very careful with them!

“You always go for the biggest sandwich!” she said jokingly.

“She said jokingly,” or “he said knowingly,”...? Seriously?

That’s an over-explanatory label and bad telling. Frankly, to me it looks like the author is desperate. Like he didn’t find any other way to express himself than hastily sticking that explanation to the end of the sentence.

You will do much better to leave out such an attachment. Instead, make your figure express the joking demeanor through her dialogue line itself. You can also use body language, it makes for great showing and will paint a nice image in your reader’s mind.

How about this?

“Oh, you...! You always go for the biggest sandwich!” She laughed and slapped his arm.

Much better. This is ‘show, don’t tell.’

A. Show don't tell descriptions

'Show don't tell' is most obvious with descriptions. Go into details! Split up that one adjective into several smaller observations. Describe enough details, and a vivid image will pop up in your reader's head.

Don't do it like this:

The Ferris wheel looked fun.

Do it like this:

The Ferris wheel had silly clowns painted on its sides, and its baskets had little umbrellas in red, green and blue as canopies.

Don't do it like this:

Tessa was a lovely lady.

Do it like this:

In came Tessa. She nodded politely in all directions, and it seemed like she acknowledged every single person with a warm smile, directed at them personally.

B. Show don't tell emotions

When you describe emotions, it's easy to forget showing. It's easy to just tell that your character feels "happy," or "sad" or "embarrassed."

But instead of *telling* how your character feels, try to *show* it; body language and dialogue are both great for that.

Don't do it like this:

Roger was bored.

Do it like this:

Roger's foot was tapping a steady rhythm onto the ground, and later he started doodling on a sheet of paper. It seemed to him like the hour would never pass.

Don't do it like this:

Erika was annoyed that Mark still hadn't returned her book about climate change.

Do it like this:

Erika looked him straight in the eye and said: "You still haven't returned my book about climate change. What are you waiting for, the polar caps to melt?"

C. Show don't tell activities

Whatever your characters are doing, you should consider 'Show, don't tell'. If the action is not very interesting or meaningful, a quick telling verb might be better. But if it's worth exploring, go deeper and *show*.

Don't do it like this:

Henrietta ate a lot that day.

Do it like this:

That day, Henrietta ate chicken with vegetable stew, a huge bowl of mixed salad, fries, and three slices of that chocolate biscuit cake she just couldn't resist.

Don't do it like this:

Milo opened the door and shot the guy in the protective suit.

Do it like this:

Milo opened the door, aimed with a calm pulse, and shot the guy in the protective suit right between the eyes.

D. Show don't tell setting/mood

If you want to get under your reader's skin with a moody setting, you have to 'show, don't tell.' What about this place evokes its mood? Describe the physical details; use nouns, verbs and senses.

Don't do it like this:

The waterfall looked majestic.

Do it like this:

The waterfall was 300 feet/100 meters high, and the cascade dropped down from the sharp cliff with roaring thunder.

Don't do it like this:

The rubbish dump at night looked creepy and unsettling to Randy.

Do it like this:

Dark trash piled up around Randy in all sorts of grotesque forms, like he was walking a deep abyss. Crooked shadows seemed to be on the hunt, and the nasty smell of plastic litter and food remains stung in his nose.

Remember!!

Even as you put descriptions into your essays, don't forget to describe with purpose. You are still to show your values, interests and personality. It's not just descriptions.